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Virginia Board of Education, Business Meeting (Part 3), Thursday, March 28, 2024

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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XSF2Sqdk29o
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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[00:00:18] okay ladies and gentlemen we are back and um coming up on item j and i believe our presenter is mr chapman thank you very much president creasy vice president hansen members of the board and dr coons item j is actually a re-presentation of an item that has been approved by the board in the past what we are doing here is actually just a change of modality and so you if you remember from the regulatory presentations, the three major types of regulatory actions are an exempt action,

[00:00:50] a fast track, and the standard regulatory process. Back with the 2021 special session, the General Assembly directed the board to develop and promulgate regulations for private special education day schools on restraint and seclusion that established the same requirements as those for public schools.

[00:01:12] And so at the time, due to the differences between the current chapter on restraint seclusion, which is directed at public schools, and the chapter for private special education day schools, there was a number of changes that had to be made in order to differ for the difference in context.

[00:01:29] So like no division superintendents, things of this sort that at the time was deemed inappropriate for an exempt action. So it was instead run as a fast track action. As this has made its way through the review process, the perspective has changed, I think, in part because of circumstance, that it's more desirable to allow this to go through the full public comment period.

[00:01:51] Despite the fact that the directive is fairly clear, you know, we believe that the text should stay the same, or at least at this point, you know, what has been done effectuates the claim. We've worked with the Office of the Attorney General to be sure that the regulatory text effectuates the mandate from the legislature.

[00:02:09] And so really what we have here is just a notice and permission for the board in order to change this and open up the full regulatory process in order to allow for public comment on the action rather than continue on the fast track process. The text remains the same as previously approved by the board. We're looking forward to receiving public comment if the board approves the action here, but we've included the full regulatory text along with this, Nora.

[00:02:36] And the superintendent's recommendation is that the board waive first review and approve this notice of intended regulatory action. Is there a motion to waive first review and approve the NORA? So moved. Second.

[00:02:53] Any discussion? Mr. Sturdefin? Aye. Ms. Kilbore? Aye. Ms. Ashton? Aye. Mr. Hanson? Aye. Mr. Rotherham? Aye. Dr. Northern? Ms. Holton? Aye. And chair votes aye.

[00:03:10] Okay. Moving on to item K. Mr. Chapman? Thank you very much, President Creasy. Members of the board, this action is a regulatory change in response to the Office of Special Education Programs' recent report that Dr. Koons gave an extended presentation on this yesterday, and this regulatory action effectuates the changes that she mentioned.

[00:03:33] Okay. Is there a motion to waive first review, approve the exempt action as presented, and delegate DOE staff authority to make additional changes as necessary to comply with the differentiated monitoring and support report for the Administrative Process Act?

[00:03:54] So moved. Second. Any discussion? Mr. Sturdefin? Aye. Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Ms. Ashton? Aye. Mr. Hanson? Aye. Mr. Rotherham? Aye. Dr. Northern? Aye. Ms. Hulton? Aye.

[00:04:09] And Chair votes aye. Thank you very much. much. Okay. Item L. Is Ms. Carol here? We will suspend for a minute, please. Thank you.

[00:04:53] Sorry for the wait. I was in the holding room. That's right. All right. It's great to talk to you all today about the regulations affecting the accreditation and accountability system in Virginia. I'm going to do a quick overview of where we are and the actions in front of you today.

[00:05:29] and then uh we'll have some time for a discussion as well um for those of you following along i'm going to go through the slides and try to call out the slides as we get to them i'm going to start with slide two in the materials is the purpose why are we here today and the reason is because uh we have an accreditation system that's not necessarily picking up some of the changes in student performance that have happened across virginia the student achievement scores have fallen uh dramatically and yet our accreditation system is not picking that up and the accreditation system has a few reasons for why that's not happening. Partly, it's using a combined rate,

[00:06:06] which combines student performance. And if students are not meeting the bar of proficiency, then it adds growth to those students. And if those students are still not meeting proficiency and not meeting growth, then it also factors in English language proficiency for English learners.

[00:06:24] And it combines all those into one thing. It's not a very clear message for the public. We know from other research that accountability system can be a helpful and transparent metric for the public, for schools to orient themselves on, here are the things that the state cares about, and here's what the schools need to do to help improve.

[00:06:48] And they also have both short and long-term gains for students. So if we identify schools that need to improve, schools often do improve, especially in math. And those gains have both short-term benefits as well as longer-term gains as well.

[00:07:05] If you turn to slide three, you can start to see some of the background. We've been talking about this, and it's been a process, and today is just another step in that process. In the fall of 22, the board held a series of work sessions from national experts to talk about accountability and the value of clear and transparent reporting of school performance, and how we can focus on outcomes and student performance as opposed to some of the inputs that go into a school. In the summer of 2023, there was a series of stakeholder meetings. The superintendent led to hear about how the districts and divisions are experiencing

[00:07:44] the accreditation system in Virginia. And then in August 2023 and September 2023, we started talking here with the board about what that could look like. And we started the process of this regulatory change. In particular, we wanted to bifurcate the system. So rather than using the accreditation system as both accreditation and accountability, having a separate school performance system in addition to the accreditation system, which can provide a baseline standard of performance for all schools. In that September meeting, we talked about at least some of the

[00:08:20] foundational elements of that new system, including a mastery index that will measure how students are performing and achieving and mastering grade-level content skills. We also talked about including student growth and how much students gain from year over year, as well as measures of readiness.

[00:08:38] So at the elementary school level, are you being prepared to be successful in middle school? In middle school, are students being prepared to be successful in high school? And once they're in high school, are they prepared to be successful in life, whether that's college or career or the military or wherever life takes them? We also talked about having a clear, transparent, summative measure. So on-school performance, combining the indicators into one overall identification of schools to have a clear differentiation of which schools need help and which schools are doing better. We also had some listening sessions in November and December that the superintendent

[00:09:16] and myself and other colleagues from VDOE went out to hear from stakeholders in the field how they're experiencing the accreditation system, some of the burdens that they're seeing and what the value they see in different measures. And that brings us to today. So the slide four is talking through the regulations and what the regulations would do they essentially would create one school performance framework that provides a clear and transparent overview of school success it also

[00:09:50] would separate out some of the indicators that i mentioned earlier the combined rate rather than combining things together it would allow for differentiation to see which schools are doing well on student performance which schools are doing well helping which schools are helping students grow from year over year it would also create one overall accountability and school performance framework that would be federally aligned so it would meet some of the federal conditions and we wouldn't have to

operate two separate systems that right now we are operating a federally compliant system the every student succeeds act state plan in addition to the

[00:10:29] accreditation system it will also allow the framework is the regulation provides us a framework. It provides a lot of flexibility for this board and future boards to add new indicators. As research suggests, new indicators are valid. It allows the board flexibility to adjust weights if they need to. It allows the forward flexibility to make different decisions if new tests come online. All of those things are flexibilities that are baked into the regulation. And it also wouldn't ding any one school and any one indicator. It would be a holistic evaluation of school

[00:11:05] performance. The other thing that's important to know is that rather than having two systems for identification, right now the VDOE is running two systems of identification. They have a federal system where they're identifying comprehensive and targeted support schools and offering them supports. Separately, we also have the accreditation system, which schools get identified and supports for those as well. The new regulations would align those systems. There would be one system that all divisions would go and have a line system of performance and they would have

[00:11:41] paperwork that was all aligned it would be focused on providing supports to the schools that need it the most um i'm going to pause there and uh take any comments or questions about the regulations precy may i make a motion may i make a motion sure um i i propose that um we consider item l with the amendments as presented by the staff which clarifies the tests that are going to be administered as well as a cut other key i think wording revisions that accurately reflect

[00:12:22] flexibility but high standards and accountability second discussion miss holton i'd like to present an alternate motion a substitute motion and that is that we adopt the regulations uh as that we accept the regulations as presented on uh first review

[00:12:53] today and defer finalizing thems and making final decisions on index weighting until after the listening sessions in april and until we have seen modeling with real data on the system's impact and alternatively i move that the proposed regulations be amended if to be adopted on final version to final proposed regs today that we amend those regulations uh as follows and i have shared my motion with i think all of the board members but it basically would change the

[00:13:29] the weightings uh the range of ratings in the regs for elementary school to the mastery index between 40 and 60 percent growth 40 up to 40 uh leaving uh that that that's all that's addressed in the regs the master the indices will be i'm sure addressing separately uh and in high schools i would my mind as as everybody has would propose that the mastery

[00:14:04] index comprise up to 20 percent of a school score and that the college and career readiness comprise up to 30 percent of a school score and that the four-year federal graduation rate comprise at least 50 percent of a school score and likewise that we add new language for middle schools saying that the mastery index be between 40 and 50 percent of school score growth up to 30 percent

[00:14:33] and readiness uh 20 up to 20 percent okay so we have motion by ms ashton that was seconded a substitute notion by miss holton miss holton if you'll withdraw the part of your uh amendment around delaying and not moving forward today and just get to the substantive issues of the discussion of the waiting i would give a courtesy second it's not something i personally support but i do think it's something that would behoove us to to discuss i would emphasize uh uh again to

[00:15:13] we re-offer your amendment without the proposal to delay and uh the other parts i again i don't support it but i i think given both your history of the commonwealth and the importance of this issue it's worth uh it's worth the discussion i will accept that i i will hope when we get to the discussion point to raise the question about whether we should be approving this matter today versus another week but i will withdraw i will delete that part from my motion and therefore move just that the right now i'm not addressing the waiting index weightings which

[00:15:49] we're going to vote on separately but rather that we make those changes to the proposed regulatory language yeah i will courtesy second that so we can have a discussion again i i'm comfortable with where we landed during the work session and and the current draft but i think it i think it behooves us to have a to have a discussion about and dr siebert's not here i suspect if he was here he would want that discussion as well okay so we had a motion that was made and properly seconded a substitute motion made and properly seconded there's discussion now on the substitute motion

[00:16:27] who would like to comment i i would like to comment miss holton thank you i appreciate some of the changes in the proposed regulations that we are seeing today but i fear that the board is moving towards making a grave mistake both as to the substance and process on this item and i'd like to share my thoughts on this topic a bit extensively here and then we'll commit not to repeat myself as as the discussion goes forward um missleton can you use your mic please thank you

[00:17:01] yes thank you uh so first we need to be clear that what the administration is proposing here is an A through F grading system for schools that may not be entirely obvious since the crucial provisions are buried in 60 pages of regulations that were only shared publicly a few days ago and they have not been highlighted in the presentations but that is what this is it may get labeled with stars or something else instead of letter grades in an attempt to soften the blow

[00:17:36] But that's what this is, as a careful reading of the proposed regulations will show. I happen to think that that's a bad approach. And I note that an overwhelming bipartisan majority of our Virginia General Assembly rejected that not that many years ago when they repealed an A through F grade school grading system for it could be implemented.

[00:18:02] Why do I think it's a bad idea? Primarily because, as research shows, it will likely exacerbate school segregation, which will in turn make our achievement gaps worse, directly counter to this board's stated goals.

[00:18:17] It's not hard to understand how that works. When you label some schools as C, D, or F schools, families and teachers who can afford to will be incentivized to move away from those schools, leaving behind the neediest students, mostly black and brown students, and the least experienced teachers.

[00:18:37] Those schools will then spiral further behind. My passion on this is grounded in my personal experience as a child and later as a parent in working to desegregate our schools. This is counterproductive. Regardless, if the board determines to adopt an A-F type system to grade our schools, I submit that the experience of other states and the research shows that two factors are crucial. First, the system must be heavily weighted towards growth measures. And second, the system must include significant resources, i.e. money, to help the failing schools improve.

[00:19:16] Now, as a board, as we discussed earlier, we don't have much power over money, but the administration is part of ongoing budget discussions with the legislature, and I hope that the

administration will now support the funds the legislature has restored to the Office of School Quality and the major funding the legislature has added to help our most challenged schools, most particularly the at-risk add-on funding, which we as a board endorsed, and English Language Learner funds, so that all this accountability pressure is not for naught. Our challenged schools especially are severely underfunded, and they cannot hire

[00:19:54] quality teachers for every classroom without more state support. Turning to what we as a board do have control over. If we want an A through F type school grading system to work, then the school grades must be heavily weighted based on measures that show whether students are growing, not just on whether they have reached proficiency, especially in the early grades. This is what the experience of other states and the overwhelming majority of experts, including our own consultants on occasion, have told us and what our own local school boards and superintendents and teachers

[00:20:33] organizations told us this morning. This is because kids start at widely different starting points, and proficiency measures just tell us that most poor kids start way behind. Sadly, our discussion yesterday suggests the board is preparing to disregard the experts and base the new system heavily on proficiency measures called mastery here that are based solely on our antiquated and flawed SOL tests. The notion seems to be that raising expectations alone will somehow magically help everyone do better. We've tried that and it did not work. As former board president

[00:21:08] Dan Gecker has said on occasion, if that were the case, we could raise the height of basketball hoops and we would all then be able to dunk. Yesterday's discussion suggests mastery will be weighted two or three times as much as growth, exactly contrary to what the experts tell us.

[00:21:35] I'm not arguing that we should ignore mastery, but rather that in elementary and middle school, we should weight growth at least equally with mastery. In high school, we all agree that we should leave growth measures behind as we move students towards graduation. Unfortunately, another major flaw in where the board appears to be heading is in downgrading the importance of high school graduation and college and career readiness as we grade our high schools, and instead judging their performance most heavily on a mastery index that is based solely

[00:22:12] on three student scores on three ninth grade SOL tests. What about the rest of high school? Our current system weighs graduation and college and career readiness heavily, and we have seen improvements, big improvements in graduation rates as school leaders and teachers and students and families have struggled mightily and often successfully to get more students over the finish line. Sadly, this board, I'm almost done. Sadly, this board seems to think our higher graduation rates must somehow mean we have watered down graduation requirements,

[00:22:51] which is exactly the opposite of the truth. We have also seen increases in the number of students taking dual enrollment and AP and IB classes and completing CTE credentials and getting work-based learning experience, all of which the proposed new weighting system will downplay by lowballing the college and career readiness measure, again, in favor of those three ninth grade SOL tests.

[00:23:16] This slavish devotion to our SOL tests is simply not well-grounded in experience and will, I fear, lead to lower graduation rates and students less well-prepared for college and career. All of this, the administration is asking the board to do through an unprecedented process, amending major regulations and making the biggest decisions about the waiting system before we give the public any meaningful opportunity to participate. The administration is scheduling listening sessions for April and would have us

accept public comment on town hall on the regs, but all of that will be after the major decisions are made today by adopting the proposed regulations

[00:23:55] that were just shared publicly three, four now business days ago, last Friday. The administration says meaningful public engagement is a major priority, but its proposed actions are inconsistent with that. A brand new study in the news today, somebody sent me a link from an MIT Nobel Prize winning economist, concludes that, quote, simple measures of school quality, which are based on the average statistics for the school, are invariably highly correlated with race, and those measures tend to be a misleading guide of what you can expect by sending your child to that school.

[00:24:32] So in addition to herding black and brown kids, we are potentially misleading all parents. Details matter. We should take time to get this right. So I encourage the board to accept the proposed regulations today on first review.

[00:24:48] We can move the ball forward so we can hear from the public and then revise them as needed through the normal process before taking the crucial next step in the APA process. and that we defer final decisions about the waiting system for the school grading system, we can adopt tentative waiting system to move forward but not finalize them until after the April listening sessions and until after we have seen modeling with real data on the system's impact, which we have been asking for for over a year. If the board is determined to go forward

[00:25:24] today, I would encourage us to wait growth at least as heavily as mastery in elementary and middle school and make graduation and college and career readiness the most important factors in judging high schools and amend the proposed regulations accordingly to facilitate those changes. Thank you. Mr. Rotherham. Madam President. Thank you, Ms. Holden. Like I said, I want to, I think we should have an airing. I'm glad you presented that. I think there's a lot of things there to unpack. I don't want to get too into whether we're rushed or not. Mr. Alderman walk through all the work we've done uh uh over the years the idea that this is just coming out of

[00:26:03] left field um is simply is simply not the case there's more process um if anything as a common wealth we haven't acted fast enough on this if you take a look at our achievement gaps you take a look at what we see when you disaggregate uh by things like race income ethnicity the way we don't talk about those things the impact on those students in particular during the pandemic but all students across the commonwealth if anything we haven't we haven't acted um uh fast enough and we have had great staff work we've had experts there are experts here right now um there's one right up here on the diets a national expert on accountability it's the idea that this is

[00:26:39] sort of been put together um you know absent the input of experts and so forth uh uh is simply is simply not true um to say that this is is and wave the sort of bloody shirt of a to f is yes there is a summative grade in here we could talk about that some sort of summative measure but this is not an a to f system and that's a way to sort of get everybody spun up create a whole bunch of you know big political storm and so forth all this is is some sort of summative measure measure to communicate to parents a summative way of thinking about all the data we're going to present and you can call it a blow but miss holton respectfully telling the truth is not a blow it

[00:27:17] It is our obligation, and it's an obligation we have failed at for far, far too long. There's flexibility in the way this is designed as we develop better tests. We talked about yesterday, you know, all

the measures that were in there, you know, were in there as examples of the kinds of things we could use. So we're not locking ourselves into SOLs for some period of time or any other test.

[00:27:40] This is going to allow us, as we look forward, not backwards, to think about how do we have a system that tells parents the truth. I'll talk more about that in just a second. I do want to respond on the school segregation. I mean, Ms. Holden, if you are just deeply concerned about that, I am so excited to work with you on school choice. We could start there. If you want to address segregation, we could stop treating school district boundaries as international borders and only allowing mostly affluent kids and things like governor schools and things like that to move across them while we trap poor kids in other districts. And so hearing your passion on that, which I share, I'm very excited to work

[00:28:17] with you on that think about what we could do on open enrollment what we could do on attendance boundaries because residential segregation is a problem in this commonwealth it's a problem in this country but there are strategies that we can use to address it and we're and we're seeing that we're not talking about school choice today but given the obvious concern about that i'm i'm certainly looking forward to those um to those conversations um uh but the idea that in any way we're going to solve those problems by not just telling people the truth about what's going on it it's not the way forward that's the way backwards the way forward is to assume the

[00:28:54] dignity of virginians not their density give them the information allow them to make choices in terms of the governance of their local schools who they want on their boards who they want uh in in various roles around the state where they want to send their kids to school we could only do that by giving them accurate information the step we're taking today is long overdue mr hansen i'd like to associate myself with mr rotherham's comments and you know the comment about segregating our schools

[00:29:31] is offensive the decline in our black and brown scores these last three or four years with our current system should it is an emergency and it is a shame on our system a shame on our commonwealth and what we're trying to do here is to bring our attention to bring our focus on accountability on helping us understand achievement mastery for all of our students and that is going to lift up

[00:30:07] our most disadvantaged and our black and brown students the most and you know dr gecker's you know basketball analogy i would actually say it's hard to view that unless we have visibility of what the standard is and visibility to have some transparency for parents to even see the rim um or we're never gonna be able to get there and i just um you know this old money challenge too is i have been working at this since the department of education in washington was created in 1979

[00:30:46] and you know it's um all these promises all the time about money and money is important bit is critically important and i actually commend this governor for making historic increases in education you know we just had a little interesting conversation before lunch about a draconian cut to a program that school superintendents want the college presidents want the local communities want and i'm still having a hard time understanding where this is coming from and so you know maybe not all education dollars are equal in the minds of people but um you know

[00:31:25] I think what this is trying to do is to get a system in place to where we can have our dollars targeted to those schools and those students that need it the most. That's what our federal programs have been designed and intended to do, whether it's IDEA or Title I or Pell Grants.

[00:31:45] This is what we need to be doing to help target our dollars to solving the problems and helping those students and those systems that need it the most. This is not some boogeyman of trying to take dollars away or to move the ball, move the goalposts.

[00:32:06] This is a way to change the system. And I also would echo Andy's comments on school choice. There is no better leveling agent. And we have this in our preschool system across the country. We have it in higher education across the country where, you know, our Pell Grant dollars, our student loan dollars don't necessarily care which type of school you go to.

[00:32:28] But those are, in essence, vouchers or grants or scholarships to send kids to the school of their choice and without boundaries. And so I just think, you know, last point, too, we've been talking about this, I've been on the board almost for two years now.

[00:32:46] And this is one of the first things that came up in our July meeting and August meeting two years ago. And that fall, we had several more conversations about this. this idea that we're trying to shove something uh across the border here is just absolutely not true and i just i think that we really should be moving forward at this and i also um on the scoring numbers that we came out with yesterday on this for elementary school if we just are not totally

[00:33:23] totally totally devoted to this three-year going on four-year learning loss of our most disadvantage of all of our students and having our system tied towards that it is shame on us and it is already i think very concerning that our uh you know that we bottomed out we we're not making progress and we need to make progress miss ashton thank you president creasy um i the i've raising expectations

[00:34:00] alone is not the one thing that's going to make this work. And as I said to the board yesterday, and I'll say again today, we have to do hard things better and this is not easy. And this framework gives us another tool to be able to direct our resources and provide transparency, but I think it's incredibly important, we've just sat for two days talking about standards, talking about resources, talking about time.

[00:34:29] We just had the most innovative proposals around how to be more innovative with college partners and universities and superintendents. It is all of those things that is going to raise the bar for our students. And unfortunately, our students don't have time.

[00:34:47] They don't have time to go through third grade, fourth grade. Our high school students don't have time again for us to delay. We have to do something about this data and it is our responsibility to move forward.

[00:35:02] And I feel incredibly confident that our leaders, our teachers, our families will be able to see that accountability framework is really the highest leverage for school improvement and it is a tool to direct resources.

[00:35:19] being said, I want to continue to emphasize that we have to stop an us versus them. We have to come together to give our tools, our leaders, our families, the tools that they need to raise the bar and allow us to have an incredibly proud, well-achieving, and happy and satisfied state Virginia. The hook in this is transparency. The summative data gives us the information.

[00:35:54] These are all indicators of a school's health. It is incredibly important that we separate these indicators. By combining them, we have no transparency. Teachers, leaders, school divisions do not have the tools to know where to put their resources. We also have to hold the bar high for mastery. I think that

this framework gives us both mastery and growth. It allows us to see who is growing the fastest, who is reaching the high bar for readiness, and the most innovative

[00:36:29] part is the readiness standards. It allows us to continue to make sense of what matters most for all of our students at their appropriate age, middle, elementary, or high school. And I would challenge us to think that this framework is actually not the ceiling. It is actually the floor, a baseline of what we should expect for all of our state to be the best and to be the most competitive. Thank you. Dr. Northern. I had the awesome privilege of going to the

[00:37:06] Virginia State, Virginia Student Council meeting. It was two Saturdays ago. And I was so excited. it was about 300 kids in the room. And I'm like, oh my gosh, I'm a former high school teacher. I get to talk to kids again. And so I had asked a number of topics to be discussed with the kids.

[00:37:26] They came up, they each got a few minutes to talk. The one thing they told me, and this is the irony of all ironies. The first thing they said was they'd really like a four day week above and beyond. And they were very serious about it. They laid out their case. But then And the next question that we got into was what was expected of them.

[00:37:49] And so many of them just honestly stood up at that microphone and said that they feel like less is expected of them now than prior to the pandemic, that they feel like school's gotten easier and they get away with a lot more with grading and disciplinary actions and they get annoyed when other students seem to be getting A's and doing nothing.

[00:38:13] I honestly, I was so encouraged that these kids were so honest and it was almost as if they were like screaming out, like we want to be held to a high standard. Like we see what's going on here and it doesn't make us feel good, right? Like you don't have faith in us. It's what they were, it was what they were saying in their own way. And so I was really struck by that, that the kids said that. And the irony of saying, okay, well, school's really not that hard, so we could probably do everything we need to do in four days, you know, is sort of how I was taking it. But so that's

[00:38:49] one point is that, you know, we're all the adults in the room. But, you know, if we had 300 kids here, like I had a couple weeks, weekends ago, then we may hear a lot more honesty in the conversation. And I'll just echo a couple quick points. You know, this is not, I think we're all stuck in the mindset that we're still in No Child Left Behind. We are so not in No Child Left Behind anymore. And I think we're looking at this through a sanction mentality. And we've said, I don't know, 500 times that this is to identify supports for schools. I don't know how many more times we can say it. And my colleague here has talked about coming alongside districts. It's not an us and

[00:39:28] them. The superintendent, I can't, how many times she's said, used the phrase arm and arm, arm and arm with the school districts and how many times she's been out talking to superintendents and such. So I really do feel like we are and not in the gotcha mentality, that we are very much in the partnership mentality, that our kids are wanting us to come alongside and raise the bar. And I will say that I think the hidden undertone is that growth is somehow easier. Well, guess what? We've got a real growth system in Virginia now. This is not the growth system we've had in prior years.

[00:40:02] So we're going to be expecting a nice chunk of growth. Like we're going to have those conversations, but lots of other states, it's at least a full year of growth before you get credit. So if anyone

thinks that growth is, you know, going to be this low bar, it's not, you know, it's going to be equally rigorous, I think, in many ways, and we've not expected in the past.

[00:40:24] And the last thing I'll say is in terms of research, like my job is research and the research I could bring in, I've done it before in this meeting, the research shows that summative, and again, it's all kind of summative. It doesn't have to be A through F. It can be any kind of, you know, any kind of signal, really, that at least gives the full picture. And of course, as we've talked about, we can have all the separate pieces too, because we want to be fully transparent. Again and again, shows that it increases student proficiency and growth, having a summative system. So, I mean, if we're going to rely on the research, then let's rely

[00:41:02] on the research in terms of that facet of this. So I'm done. Madam President. Mr. Sturdifant. You know, you hear the term of, you know, the hand up versus the handout. Lowering the standards is a handout. All kids need to be uplifted. And what I've heard today, I've heard it a few times, and I guess I need to address it. This is all about black and brown kids, which is not. You know the black and brown kids and poor kids is a trigger that's used quite often to get people

[00:41:38] fired up to support a cause. I've heard slavish devotion to SOL, black and brown kids and slavish devotion to an SOL. They're all triggers. They're to get people fired up. And when I heard that, I thought this is a strange place for me right now. Every kid deserves the best educational opportunity in the Commonwealth. We need to have high standards. I'm more of an 80-10-10, but I know we're not going to get there. But we should never consider luring anything.

[00:42:19] The analogy of raising a basketball rim up to 12 feet. First, you got to get on the court. First, you got to make the team. You got to work to make the team. This is an age of participation trophies where we just want to hand stuff out. I believe kids should work hard every day. They need to know what it's like to fail, to not make a team. But when I constantly hear brown and black kids and

[00:42:52] poor kids. There are a lot of, what is Virginia, 19% African-American? 19%. So if we're talking about majority, we'll be talking about the other majority being impacted more. But we use black and brown to push an agenda or a point. I will not support Ms. Holton's motion. I will support the first motion. I think we should strive to increase at every level, at every level, the difficulty of our courses. Because if you raise the bar, you may not make it. But you're still at a higher point

[00:43:29] than having that low bar where kids are being told or certain school divisions, no child left behind, no child ever fails. Everyone just keeps getting pushed forward. When that person becomes an adult, it's the school's fault. It's our community's fault. So anytime I hear this idea of not wanting to increase rigor, I shake my head. And when I hear, you know, black and brown, it directly relates to African-American slavery. People that were enslaved have come a long ways,

[00:44:05] not because things were given to them, but because they had an opportunity to go to a school, not going to a school where the standard was low. A friend of mine went to school in Farmville. She just wrote a book. I told you about her, Ms. Olten. They shut school down because of racial issues. She finally got her GED last year, and I bought her 10 first books, and I wanted her to sign the books so I can give them to my children. She wrote in cursive.

[00:44:44] Our kids today can't write in cursive, so their standard was higher back then than it is now. So at every level, I believe in raising the standards, and any time I hear, let's lower it, let's make it easy, I run

away from that and I oppose it.

[00:45:06] So I will close this by saying I will support the first motion strongly. Thank you, Madam President. Any further comments? Can I come for the question? Please. Thank you. so I'm not responding to anything because I promised I wouldn't but I do think my motion needs to be voted on that's correct we are getting ready to do that that's correct so Ms. Kilgore requested that we call the question and the question is whether or not we approve this is on the regulation not on the waiting those will be separate votes however on the

[00:45:46] regulation. We are currently voting on Ms. Holton's amendments that she presented to us. And so with that, I will... Point of order. Sure. We're voting on the parts not involving delaying the regulation. That's correct. Okay. Correct. Voting on the substitute. As a whole.

[00:46:10] As a whole. As a whole. As a whole. Divide it up in parts if anybody wanted to. If that enabled you to vote for different parts of it, but I don't hear there's any. As a whole should be better. as a whole minus the first section which the substitute has taken out okay um miss kilgore nay miss ashton nay mr hansen no mr rotherham no uh dr northern nay uh mr sturdifant nay

[00:46:40] miss holton yes and chair votes nay okay so that takes us to the original motion uh which was um the document that you that miss ashton's motion um so these are the amendments that you see with the document uh title item l test amendments um and for that we will vote on the amendments and then the amended regulation as a whole and i'm like can i clear point of clarification is miss

[00:47:19] holton is the motion to adopt the proposed regs on first and final stage with these changes that's correct is that clear yes so the proposed amendments that are here item l would be incorporated into the proposed regs and so this would be the regs with the amendments vote everyone

[00:47:51] clear yeah no you have a question yeah i would also we've had a request from dr siebert which i would with that we all these school performance reports and that school performance report cards we've been advised. That will not put us out of compliance with federal law.

[00:48:09] Okay. Would you consider that a friendly amendment to add to these? Okay. My amendment would be specifically so it can be made in second. It would be that we school performance reports, not school performance report, cards pursuant to any federal law or regulation. So minus the word cards. Yes, Madam President.

[00:48:38] everybody clear on that so we had an additional amendment to add to the item l which amends school performance report card to school performance report okay so this vote is all amendments plus the first review and approval of the regulations themselves everybody understand

[00:49:04] Okay. Mr. Sturdifant? Aye. Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Ms. Ashton? Aye. Mr. Hanson? Yes. Mr. Rotherham? Aye. Dr. Northern? Aye. Ms. Holton? No. And chair votes aye. Okay. So we will move to, is there a motion on for the preferred waiting for elementary school performance framework at 65% mastery, 25% growth, and 10% readiness?

[00:49:40] okay i'm sorry can you say the numbers again 65 mastery 25 growth 10 readiness in elementary school any discussion i would miss holton i would argue that we should uh change those numbers to

[00:50:11] 40 growth 40 mastery and 20 readiness for the reasons i stated previously okay so you are presenting a substitute motion? I'm not going to. Are you presenting an original motion? I'm doing it by

way of discussion and would raise a motion if anybody was interested in seconding it. I would be happy to make the motion, but other than that, I'll just do it by way of discussion. I think that number weights mastery almost three times growth contrary to the research. Any comments, discussion?

[00:50:50] okay um just discussion mr rotherham discussion on the underlying or discussion on miss holton's motion that i didn't make one oh okay just discussion on the underlying yeah i don't want to put mr uh alderman on the spot but i'm going to um uh could you i mean we keep hearing that experts say we must and and first of all in education like you know experts say it's like a find and replace modifier and everything but can you just talk a little bit about i mean you're a national expert. You see this across the country. You study this across the country. You've been

[00:51:29] doing it in a very influential way for years since way into the No Child Behind era. Is this idea that growth should be at least equally weighted? Is this somehow sacrosanct? Talk about the process here. I think it's important for the public because there's this idea that we're just sort of rushing forward, disregarding the experts. And rather than any of us, I think my views on accountability are pretty clear, I think, from somebody like you who has studied this and might be useful too for the purpose of discussion. Sure. I would start my remarks by seconding something that Dr. Northern said, that this is a huge step forward for Virginia to measure growth

[00:52:08] and report growth. There is growth currently in the accreditation system, but it's buried. You can't find it for individual schools. And so public rating systems like greatschools.org, they use growth in other states. They can't use it for Virginia because it's not publicly disaggregated so this will be a big step forward that virginia has growth in a real way to your question mr rotherham it's a lot of uh art rather than a science and uh the regulation gives the board flexibility to revise those going forward the weights that we're discussing today i would say are not out of line with other states they would be on the higher side of achievement there

[00:52:48] are some states that have gone like virginia's proposing right now to be higher achievement there are some states that have gone higher on growth and i don't think anyone could say there's a right or wrong so i do think it's it's a judgment call at this point in time all right now i appreciate that i think and i'll just say in my judgment i mean we need to take into account growth and we do in these models but fundamentally parents send their kids to schools to get there not to just be getting there and we've heard you know from from different board members in in different ways across the dais the importance of having sort of high expectations that are clear

[00:53:23] concrete so that our educators can rise to that challenge and i firmly believe they will i reject this idea that if we set the bar or the basketball hoop or whatever that they're not going to be able to jump to i think quite the opposite they they will jump to a to a to a uh and be able to achieve a demanding standard and that is what parents expect they expect mastery and so i think the waiting is appropriate mr hansen and i just like to remind everybody too that to your point that maybe we're at the higher end about 15 months ago we heard a report from dr schneider from the

[00:53:56] national center for educator education sciences that virginia had dropped to the most of any state in the country um our negative bar was the biggest outlier of anybody and so again we have in my mind a corollary um uh model that we're trying to to go after here to solve for that massive change or decline that we've had as a state any other comments miss holton follow-up

[00:54:30] just a question and follow-up to mr rotherham mr um alderman do you agree disagree then with dr petrilli the president of fordham institute in the article that uh miss uh dr northern sent us where he says that growth should be weighted, I think he says seven or eight, nine times proficiency. And do you disagree with Dr. Chester Finn, who said in the former president of the Fordham Institute? Ms. Hulton, keep your comments to the motion. Said that it's your question.

[00:55:03] Follow up to, yes, it is. Dr. Finn said that both growth and proficiency should be basically equally weighted in a placement placement approach do you disagree with those experts uh those i respect both those people immensely and they're i would consider them friends uh i just would fall back to what i said earlier it's it's more art than science and it's up to the board's judgment to decide where to set the bar um rather than there's a solid line those those are two experts from the same organization that disagree and so there's a lot of disagreement in the field right

[00:55:39] right now as well. Okay. Mr. Sturdifant? Aye. Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Ms. Ashton? Aye. Mr. Hansen? Aye. Mr. Rotherham? Aye. Dr. Northern? Aye. Ms. Holton? No. Chair votes aye. Okay. Now we will move to middle school. Is there a motion for the preferred waiting for the middle school performance framework at 65% mastery, 20% growth, and 15% readiness?

[00:56:17] So moved. Second. Any discussion? Dr. Northern? I mean, I expressed my thoughts yesterday and just want to, you know, say again that I'm really excited about what we're doing in the readiness space in the middle school level, and I had expressed an interest in, you know, doing 60-20-20, and I think our speaker earlier also, you know, just reiterated the excitement that he has about some offering some of these mathematics classes in middle school that have never been done before.

[00:56:54] So I really would like to incentivize that piece. So, you know, my friendly amendment would be 60-20-20, but just put that in front of the board for discussion and comment. And I'm sorry, what was the first motion?

[00:57:11] 65% mastery, 20% growth, 15% readiness. So may I, by way of discussion, suggest that I would go middle school, same as with elementary, 40% growth, 40% mastery, 20% readiness.

[00:57:27] other comments okay um hearing none mr sturdifant i i mean do you want to it wasn't a substitute motion which would there would have been there is a motion on the floor it was properly made and seconded and then miss i'm sorry dr northern said that she wanted to make an amendment it would need

[00:58:01] to be a substitute motion for that a substitute motion rub 60 2020. sorry i did not use the correct verbiage and i would courtesy second her motion as a just as a courtesy so that would be 60 mastery 20 growth 20 readiness is that correct dr northern yes ma'am okay um so let's take that any discussion on that yeah i think i don't think this does any violence to the idea i mean

[00:58:40] we're having this peculiar discussion where we're being somehow like from some quarters accused that we're like our standards are going to be too high relative to other states which like guilty um uh but like i don't think this does any uh does any violence to that idea we have heard some kind of thought mr truett's comments this morning were very interesting so i would have no problem support supporting this the ready the readiness measures are rigorous measures it's not like we're not introducing uh we're not reducing fuzziness i have no problem supporting uh miss miss northen's

[00:59:14] proposal nor do i so then i'll withdraw my motion okay so the substitute motion contains 60 mastery 20 growth 20 readiness everybody clear on that okay mr sturdifan aye miss kilgore miss ashton aye mr hanson mr rotherham dr northern miss holton no and chair votes aye

[00:59:50] Okay. Is there a motion for the preferred weighting for high school performance framework at 50% mastery, 35% readiness, and 15% graduation? So moved. Second. Any discussion?

[01:00:07] I would like to, on this one, I will make a substitute motion to preserve significant weight for graduation, specifically 50% for graduation, 20% for mastery, 30% for the readiness.

[01:00:28] That's my substitute motion. I'm sorry, say that again. 50% graduation, 20% mastery, 30% readiness for high school. Okay, is there a second to the substitute motion?

[01:00:57] Okay, that motion fails for lack of a second. So the original motion is 50% mastery, 35% readiness, 15% graduation. Any further comments, discussion?

[01:01:16] Mr. Sturdifant? Aye. Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Ms. Ashton? Aye. Mr. Hansen? Mr. Rotherham? Dr. Northern? Aye. Ms. Holton? No. Chair votes aye. Okay. And now we

[01:01:31] move to item M. Thank you. Our English team. Use me, Mike. Let the record reflect that I should

[01:02:36] have said Mr. Petrilli, not Dr. Petrilli. Okay, you ladies ready for us? Yes. All right. Go right ahead, please. Good afternoon again, everyone. Again, we have Jill Negaris and Colleen Cassida with us today, yesterday, and I'm sorry you missed the presentation, but okay, great. So yesterday, you were able to hear the presentation on the proposed standards of learning, and we were able to make an edit last night. You should have in front of you what we do not. Here you go. It should

[01:03:15] be there, but I have another one right here. Thank you. And so before you, you have where we have added in four standards of learning as requested around memorization. And this is related to seventh grade standards, ninth grade standards, 10th grade and 12th grade. So we begin this standard in the middle school and continue it on through the 12th grade. So that addition should be reflected in your packet in the strikethrough version, the redline version,

[01:03:54] as well as the other two documents, the side-by-side. And we've kind of highlighted it for you and put it in yellow so it stands out in your package. And so we are asking for approval of the proposed 2024 English Standards of Learning today. And that's what you got for us, huh? Okay.

[01:04:19] Is there a motion to approve the proposed 2024 English Standards of Learning for implementation in 2425 and authorize the VDOE to make final clarifying and or technical edits. Are there any is there any discussion? Dr. Northern? I just want to thank the staff and the superintendent who whom I've got a text this morning at 730 because she was going back and forth with staff trying to really work on this these memorization standards and I just

[01:04:54] appreciate it i really do think that our kids are are really going to um enjoy having this uh standard and i think that because we've got it starting in middle school it's really going to bring uh start that speaking and presentation skills early and then it'll carry on into high school and as i understand it they've uh organized it so that um they can do it in the years that they don't have the uh the writing exam so i think they took some care into the timing of it as well So I'm excited one day because we're going to

having students come in, and my hope is that one day we'll have them come in and recite some of these poems and speeches and all these other passages that they're learning.

[01:05:33] So I just wanted to publicly thank you guys for working so quickly. I know that, you know, it can be a little bit of a pain sometimes to have a board. I think many of us on this panel have our own board, so we sit on the other side as well trying to make them content. uh so so thank you again for for your hard work and uh for your uh addition of that important standard thank you any other comments okay um motion has been made and properly seconded

[01:06:07] so um seeing that there's no other discussion mr certifan hi miss kilgore hi miss ashton hi mr hanson all right mr rotherham hi dr northern hi miss holton hi and chair votes i okay thank you very much. Really fantastic work. Thank you. Thank you. Okay, so we're moving on to written presentations and reports, and I am responsible for this next presentation. So, would you all

[01:06:42] rather me sit here or stand over there? Oh, you want a break? Okay, five minutes. Thanks. You should stand when you come back.

[01:06:59] Okay, so we are back and we are calling our friend, Mr. Rotherham. Okay, so I am responsible for the next presentation. And just by way of an introduction to my presentation, I'm sure you have all read it. It's essentially very similar to what has been posted on the DOE website for a number of years with a few updates and some changes.

[01:17:42] But what we wanted to do is just give a brief synopsis of public charter schools in Virginia. And remember that we have a definition within the code that public charter schools in Virginia are non-sectarian, non-religious, non-home-based within a public school division.

[01:18:03] And what I would say is that the following two bullets are pretty important, too. So public charter schools may be created as a new public school or the conversion of an existing public school, but they cannot be converted into public charters through a private school or a non-public home-based education program.

[01:18:28] So those of you who know the history of charters in Virginia know that in 1998, public charter schools were first authorized in Virginia. And we've gone through a number of different pieces of legislation throughout the years, since 1998, all the way to our most recent legislation in 2017, I guess.

[01:18:53] But I think what's really important here is what's on slide four and slide five, really around the requirements of the board in the process of approving charter schools.

[01:19:11] And then in slide number five, what the local school board's responsibilities are, and those two pieces here are really important for the board to make themselves aware of and understand.

[01:19:28] And so at the end of this meeting, I will have a comment and request that, yes, I just remembered. And if you guys would go to the very last slide, you'll see the charter schools that are currently operating and in what school divisions here in the Commonwealth current, excuse me, currently, as well as the grade levels that those charter schools support.

[01:19:54] So it is my understanding that we currently have two charter school applications that are waiting in the wings for us to be reviewing. And Dr. Armstrong is going to come up and talk about a couple of things here in his report.

[01:20:12] But at the very end of our meeting, I'll have a further comment about this particular process and how we are going to move forward with those applications. Do you need to have anything to say, Dr. Armstrong, or is your presentation just submission of the written report?

[01:20:29] Okay. So Dr. Armstrong reported that he is happy to answer any questions that one might have from the board on his report, should anyone have a question on anything that's contained in that report.

[01:20:52] Are there any questions? Okay. Madam President, more general comment. I mean, we had a lively discussion earlier about are we going to look forwards or backwards on what we're doing? I think charter schools are another example.

[01:21:08] Is every charter school in this country a great school? absolutely not. But the data is very clear. They've been systematically improving as a sector over the, you know, that's the best data on that is out of Stanford, the Credo Center at Stanford. They've been improving. Most are as good or better. As good is not necessarily the standard we should aspire for, but those schools are creating different kinds of opportunities for kids and parent choice. The better, the ones, especially the ones that are significantly better are quite remarkable so you have schools for example charter schools in boston essentially effectively double the school year so you kids are getting 180 extra days of learning in those

[01:21:48] schools compared to the schools they would have been in which is we talk about extending learning time and you know a little bit in the summer like that that's doubling it that's just remarkable um you see that across the sort of urban charter school sector so in major cities where you've had you know um uh real real growth um and so i think it's a place where we just need to have a more serious conversation, you know, here in the Commonwealth, and if we're serious about the legacy of racialized attendance zones, you know, school district boundaries, sort of all the racial history there, if we're actually serious about addressing that and addressing those issues,

[01:22:24] things like charter schools are going to have to be part of the solution because they do sever that link between people's personal wealth, where they're able to afford to live, and the kind of educational opportunities they have. And again, looking forward, I don't know how we can not be having conversations about how do we do that? How do we sever that link?

[01:22:44] Dr. Norther? I'm just going to make a comment. I mean, our law is different than most other states' laws because, if I'm reading slide 15 correctly, that we actually review the application for soundness and feasibility and so on and so forth, and then it's up to the local school board to then decide whether or not they want to accept that school, and so I would just encourage, I don't know who these applicants are, but because this is sort of, in my view, it's a little

[01:23:21] backwards, right, because normally we would see the local school district coming forward and supporting its own school, that we should encourage these applicants to approach the local school board even before they approach us and to establish some positive relationships and some collaboration there that will bode well for them to be accepted by their local school.

[01:23:43] Yes. And so speaking of that process, I will make a comment at the end of our meeting regarding that process, but we have had a charter school advisory committee that has kind of gone defunct, and I will speak to that at the end of this meeting. Thank you. Ms. Holton? Madam President, you may have said this before, so forgive me if I missed it, but am I correct in understanding that essentially

the board portion of the charter school process is voluntary, that a school, a proposed new charter school can simply go directly to a local board and get authorized

[01:24:22] without having to come to us at any stage, or do they have to come to us? They have to come to us first. But they have to come to us first, but the ultimate decision maker is the local board. That's correct. I think I'm correct in understanding that's based on the interpretation of the Constitution.

[01:24:41] That's correct. And thank you. And then I have a comment in response to Mr. Rotherham's comments, if I may. I'd be interested to know, I guess it's really a question and maybe we can have this conversation offline, but when you talk about ending boundaries to racialized attendance zones, are you supporting a mandatory right of students and families to cross jurisdictional

[01:25:15] boundaries such that, for instance, kids in Richmond City could choose to go to Chesterfield or Henrico schools and Chesterfield and Henrico schools would be required to accept them? I mean, right now we have a system where if you can afford to do that, you can do that. And you can afford to do that by two ways. You can afford, we say, and lots of people say, well, I send my kids to public schools. I send my kids to public schools, but not everybody can afford to live where i live there's a high property tax burden high just median property value so that's the first way so we've created the system where you can buy in if you if you have wealth the second

[01:25:52] way is there's explicit provisions across the commonwealth where districts let your divisions you know let you come in again if you can pay and i think like if we're actually serious about how do we expand opportunity and so forth you can't have a system that it's going to work for the affluent then of course there's the other kind of workarounds you have certain selective schools and so forth where you know income is not necessarily the the prerequisite to get in but if you look at the demographics it certainly it it certainly helps so i think there's a conversation to be had about what does that look like what does open enrollment look like i know open enrollment's been an issue that's been debated here you know very recently here um and we need to start thinking

[01:26:32] about what are the kinds of incentives we can create what are the kinds of opportunities personally do i i think we want to make sure parents have more opportunities you should not have a choice the choice we offer in the state in public education should not be the one school you're zoned into whether or not it's working for you for whatever reason or having to figure out a way to either go private or move to me that's not a sustainable political system over time and we're you know we're seeing sort of gentle erosion around enrollment this isn't the only cause but i think it's one so we have to have we have to have a conversation there i'm a bit of a dissenter i will say in the charter world a lot of people think you should automatically be able to bypass

[01:27:08] local school districts i don't have a problem with going to the local school board i mean you want these things as we talked about accountability other things these things are should be collaborative not adversarial but there is a problem it is a constitutional problem as you noted and so it needs to be fixed not by this board but it needs to it needs to be fixed by the legislature and the citizens where essentially our system right now and i don't mean to be glib but this really is what it's like is essentially if you want to open a five guys in your community you need to get mcdonald's to say that it's okay and you just can't it just doesn't work like that some divisions and we have uh pam moran who was you know very uh enlightened school superintendent

[01:27:45] who wanted to open charter schools in albemarle and did and so some places are going to be fantastic on that other places are going to be more resistant so you need some sort of meaningful appeals process or other avenue again always anchored in quality obviously um and there's again around the country there's plenty of examples what i'm describing is not some exotic animal that nobody has ever seen it's washington dc for example just across the river so um so so there is there is potential here um it's just a place where we have we have traditionally we have traditionally lagged behind and i i believe and i think one place you and i are very aligned is on questions of funding if you want taxpayers to fund the schools we have to

[01:28:24] make sure we're giving them lots of options that are going to be choices of first resort not last resort for them. Madam President, I'd just like to point out that another division in the state that has several charters is Richmond City right here. Absolutely. And proud of them. With another, if I may, another fantastic superintendent. Thank you. I agree. But my question to you is, I think that what breaks down in the system you're proposing is that the willingness of those essentially suburban divisions to be currently their openness is contingent on their willingness

[01:29:03] to accept students from the city schools etc and they're mostly not willing and uh um i wonder whether you're willing to advocate for forcing those suburban divisions to accept schools from from neighboring jurisdictions i i was part of the as you know integrating richmond city schools

[01:29:26] There was a decision made by the judge I later worked for, Judge Marriage, at some point to consolidate the Richmond, Henrico, and Chesterfield schools, and it was struck down by the Supreme Court on a 4-4 vote when Lewis Powell couldn't participate because he'd been previously on the Richmond City School Board.

[01:29:43] So that didn't happen. And now what we have is jurisdiction lines, essentially, that are drawn to preserve racial segregation in our schools. And we have, I don't want to speak specifically for current leadership in any specific counties, but historically we have the suburban schools being not the least interested in voluntarily accepting large numbers of students from other jurisdictions.

[01:30:12] Well, and would you change that? Well, yeah, and I do. And by the just as I do believe Justice Powell is on this board as well. Am I mistaken? I do. Ladies and gentlemen, we are delving into a policy debate, which I would rather take offline.

[01:30:29] Much appreciated. What I will say is that I challenge local school divisions not only to engage with opportunities for charter schools, to allow charter schools to engage in conversations, but to also embrace the opportunities that charter schools provide and not just embrace them on the front end.

[01:30:57] continue to embrace them, continue to do what they are supposed to do, which is consider them just like any other school in their school division. And so that is a challenge that I think we have in the current system in some places where some school divisions that have charter schools often are not as collaborative as they could be. And so I hope that we see that this is about providing students opportunities families opportunities to do different things

[01:31:34] because if you go and look at the list of charter schools that we have now many of those charter schools provide things that are not provided in any other school in the districts so we will move on to item p please you want to go ahead and dr coons is it okay if i take a point of privilege So I am so excited that

Kelly Bizzano is coming up to the dais because I first met Kelly when she was talking about how important fine arts are, how important they are for our children, and the opportunities are important.

[01:32:13] And then she proceeded to tell me her resume that she was the past national president of Visual Arts Association of State Leaders and all of the work she's done and that she works with an entity that is doing national studies on chronic absenteeism and fine arts and student engagement in the Commonwealth.

[01:32:33] And as many of you on this day as know, Emily Ann and I are on a mission to change our chronic absenteeism numbers because it's about student engagement and making sure our students are engaged in school every day because our schools have the best opportunities for resources and wraparound supports to help them reach the bar and continue above the bar.

[01:32:57] So I'm incredibly grateful for her advocacy for all fine arts across the state. She has put on the display this morning for the Fine Arts Month, and she will continue to bring fine arts to us every month. And I'm really excited about her work and her advocacy in this. So I want to tell you how excited I am about this presentation, one, but of the champion work that Kelly is doing across the Commonwealth. So thank you very much, Kelly.

[01:33:25] Thank you for that introduction. And I have about a 10 minute presentation to follow along the slide presentation you have. President Creasy, Superintendent Coons, and members of the board, thank you for the opportunity to share this brief presentation on enrollment trends for fine arts education in Virginia.

[01:33:43] I'm the coordinator of fine arts for the Department of Education, a role I've been in for five years. Data found in this report comes from a few sources. First, the Virginia Coalition for Fine Arts Education works with a national partner, Quadrant Research, to create and publish a public arts education dashboard based on data found in Virginia's longitudinal data system.

[01:34:07] The Virginia Commission for the Arts financially supports the Virginia Arts Education Data Project. The dashboard offers a deep and comprehensive look at arts enrollment from the state level down to the school level.

[01:34:23] It includes course enrollment trends, student demographics, changes over time, and more. The dashboard is online and available to the public, community members, educators, and leaders. And I have shared that link with Jim who can send it out at your request. In addition, I've used data sources available to DOE employees related to arts enrollment.

[01:34:45] And finally, Quadrant Research has prepared a special report for Virginia on data correlations between chronic absenteeism and fine arts enrollment. On to slide two, at VDOE, the term fine arts refers to disciplines of dance arts, theater arts, music, and visual arts.

[01:35:06] Numerous courses fall within these disciplines, including courses that in some states they call a fifth discipline called Media Arts. In Virginia, courses related to digital, visual arts and design, and music and theater production that may fall within Media Arts in other states already fall within these four disciplines in Virginia.

[01:35:26] So we have not taken action to add the fifth discipline of Media Arts in our state yet, even though those types of courses are widely available and growing. This presentation gives a glimpse of

enrollment in fine arts programs across the Commonwealth.

[01:35:42] The enrollment data highlights Virginia's historic and long-standing commitment to including fine arts programs as part of the comprehensive academic program of schools. Students, parents, educators, division, and state leaders support local school fine arts programs.

[01:36:01] There are K-12 standards of learning for each of these four disciplines. And now I'll start providing a snapshot of enrollment data on slide 3. Last year, over 770,000 of Virginia's 1.1 million students were enrolled in at least one fine arts course.

[01:36:21] That's 71% of Virginia's K-12 students. To determine what course is defined as a fine arts course, the data refers to courses with a SCED code identified as being a fine arts discipline. On slide four, the data shows that fine arts enrollment in Virginia is steady over five years.

[01:36:42] Statewide, fine arts courses have not seen a decrease in enrollment due to disruptions in learning of the COVID-19 pandemic. On slide five, last year, over 38% of all high school students were enrolled in at least one fine arts course.

[01:37:00] Several high school courses show significant enrollment increases, and those include musical theater introduction to theater and technical theater music technology piano guitar sculpture and ceramics studio art digital art and design and courses in dance on the next slide over the last five years virginia has seen a 17 increase in enrollment in ap and ib courses within fine arts disciplines this points to an increase in offerings in rigorous advanced courses that

[01:37:37] prepare students for post-secondary opportunities in the arts. On slide seven, last school year 74 percent of middle school students were enrolled in at least one fine arts course, and Virginia is seeing significant increases in middle school theater, that's our highest increase in middle school, as well as digital art and design and music technology courses. At the elementary level, as you know, the Code of Virginia requires each school to provide instruction in art and music, and this means that every elementary student receives instruction in art and music each year

[01:38:16] in most schools that means that every elementary student takes art and music every week of every year dance and theater are also increasingly being offered to elementary students art education is a full part of the lives and the education experiences of virginia students on slide nine one of the really compelling pieces of data we've uncovered is the correlation between fine arts enrollment at the high school level and reduced rates of chronic absenteeism a special report from quadrant research

[01:38:51] found that seniors enrolled in four years of fine arts courses each year since 2020 have demonstrated a 32 percent to 50 percent lower absenteeism rate than those who did not take a fine arts course during high school and these findings hold true when comparing data across fine arts disciplines and for key variables such as race ethnicity enrollment and free and reduced price meal programs and english learners these findings are part of a full report that we'd be happy to make available to you and the report shows that students who enroll even in just one fine

[01:39:28] arts course in high school have a more favorable attendance rating i have one final slide to share on slide 10. A high school graduation requirement for both standard and advanced diplomas is that students graduate with at least one credit in either CTE or Fine Arts. To add some perspective to that requirement, I want you to see that 42 percent of Virginia students graduate with at least one Fine Arts

credit, which is a 31 percent increase over five years. CTE programs are also increasing. According to the data, 85 percent of students graduate with at least one CTE course,

[01:40:07] and that's a 13% increase to students graduating with a CTE credit. 34% of students, about a third of Virginia students, graduate with both CTE and Fine Arts credit. A potential takeaway from this data is that with good scheduling practices, students can follow either CTE, Fine Arts, or concurrent pathways in both CTE and Fine Arts. Fine Arts and CTE can be an and and doesn't have to be an oar. In 2020, the Board of Education adopted revised fine arts standards that improved

[01:40:42] the alignment of arts programs to 21st century workplace readiness skills and post-secondary readiness. Since then, we've created resources that demonstrate how students in fine arts programs are preparing for the 21st century workplace and for post-secondary pathways both in and outside of creative industries. Virginia's employers value workers who can think creatively and work collaboratively, which are just some of the important skills emphasized in all Virginia

[01:41:15] fine arts programs. According to the Americans for the Arts, arts and culture businesses in Virginia employ over 100,000 people and account for 3.1% of the state's GDP. Arts and culture industries generated 8.1 billion dollars in revenue in 2015. In the Richmond area alone, audiences of 5.9 million people generated 360 million dollars for the city. The full inclusion of fine arts programs in public education means business for Virginia. In honor of Youth Art Month, Music in Our Schools

[01:41:55] Month, and Theater in Our Schools Month, thank you to this board for honoring the importance of fine arts education as part of Virginia's comprehensive and best-in-class public education system. The data presented in this report is just a glimpse into the state of fine arts education in Virginia, which is strong and steady. Thank you for your time and hearing this report and I would be happy to respond to any questions you have. Are there any questions board members have here? I would

[01:42:29] just like to echo what you said. I taught middle school for 10 years and one, I can assure you that the classroom that all of my students wanted to be in was the band teacher's classroom um and i shouldn't say this the way i'm going to say it so it might sound a little bit weird they have the most incredible opportunities to make music come alive or theater come alive or whatever art come

[01:43:02] alive. And those teachers are seriously special people that can take their creativity and display it like they do for students. And so thank you for what you do for the department and your commitment to fine arts, for your commitment to fine arts education in the Commonwealth. And I would just like to say thank you to all of our fine arts teachers and those parents and families that support those teachers um and those programs across the commonwealth because those are some

[01:43:40] seriously supportive parents i can tell you so thank you very much thank you are there any other comments thank you thank you again have a good one uh okay mr gilstrap do you have a presentation do you want to speak because it doesn't say just written report here for me so i am available to answer any questions if anyone has it. It's a 120-page report, so I don't think that everyone's read the whole thing. I will tell you the highlights of it are it's from 2021. If you want to come up

[01:44:15] so that you got a microphone, please. I'll just point out that the highlights are that it's from 2021 to 2023, and 100% of all of our EPPs, IHEs, met the requirement and are able to move forward with their programs. So that was one very positive thing that came out of this. Thank you. Any questions on this report no okay um discussion of current issues anybody have anything dr coons

[01:44:48] you have something i have something two somethings well let let's let you all go first miss holton so i just wanted to raise up for the board's consideration and particularly dr coons one letter we got in public comment from a student in prince william county schools rindia latif who is participating in i i think participating both with prince william special olympics and a program called unified sports and as i understand it the i'm familiar with this in other jurisdictions not in prince william but it's a program that essentially has students of differing abilities

[01:45:26] uh engaging together in physical activity and games and pe and um i i want to applaud the effort first of all i think it's just a remarkable learning experience for everybody involved and i think i understand the the letter to have a specific request which is she's trying to get the board of education us to approve the unified pe course as an option to meet the health and pe graduation requirements apparently there is a course it's offered in some schools within prince william and not others she doesn't offer us any information on elsewhere in the state but it

[01:46:04] Apparently, that unified sports course does not qualify as the health and PE graduation requirement. And there may be, you know, maybe it doesn't do everything our standards of learning, our SOLs require.

[01:46:20] So there may have to be modifications. But I would like to ask Dr. Coons if we can look into that and if you can report back to us at the appropriate time on what it would take to get us to the point of approving the unified PE course.

[01:46:35] as an option to meet health and PE graduation requirements. It's just a really extraordinary program and we should do everything we can to support it. It's gonna create new special ed teachers, among other things. - I am more than happy to reach out to Dr. McDade and find out more about Unified PE.

[01:46:51] - Thank you. - Dr. Northern. - I was just, something that we do in work in Ohio and my organization is just provide all the legislators there just with a little packet of education facts figures it has no spin it has no explanation it has no nothing and we have seen year after year how they've come to really rely on this information and how it's how it's been really a way for them to support the work of folks in ohio so i was going to just pass around what this thing looks like and how one day it would be great if we in virginia could put together just all facts

[01:47:32] and hand them out to folks in our general assembly that will be a great resource for them and help them understand uh you know just some pivotal information we're working on and perhaps as a as a tool for us to work together anybody else all right i have a couple of things but do you want to go first or do you want me to go first um so next month i am excited that we get to hear from i know we talked about this briefly maybe yesterday at some point but i did want to just um make sure

[01:48:10] that those of the public is aware that next month we will hear from our student advisory committee which I am extremely excited about. I was able to participate in one of their recent meetings and Dr. Armstrong is not in here right now but he was a part of that meeting as well and it was very exciting. The kinds of questions that students were engaging in and the feedback that they were giving was just really extraordinary. And I feel certain that their engagement in this

[01:48:48] way is going to really impact the work that we do. And so I'm so excited about this opportunity. The second opportunity that I want to bring is following up with on my brief report on charter schools.

And with that, I would like to reestablish the charter school advisory committee of this board and I have spoken with um Miss Ashton and asked her if she would share that committee and she has agreed to do so with her expertise I believe that we have someone who our applications

[01:49:27] will be in very good hands with so I'm very excited about that and we'll have further information about other members of that committee so if you're interested in that please do let me know and then finally for my comments this afternoon yesterday morning when i came in i was super excited jim was introducing me to a new member of the doe staff our new regulatory coordinator his name is connor skelly and before jim even said i'd like to introduce you i said connor and so this is such a cool full circle moment for me because um i taught connor in seventh

[01:50:06] grade and he was in my seventh grade civics class and so that was super special to me and I got on the phone with my mom on the way home and she started crying my mom's a former teacher and then I started crying like that was the full circle moments as a teacher when you get to see um you know what your students have done and where they are in their lives now it's just super special and so here I am gonna get all choked up about it again but um so anyway really awesome and exciting uh time to have connor come and join the staff so very excited for that madam

[01:50:43] president i forgot to ask about that's very exciting miss holton i forgot to ask about a housekeeping matter there's been some discussion about moving our june meeting date i do have other things i'm scheduling and yes love to hear if we've resolved that and also there's been some suggestion that we might have a may meeting which i'm not in favor of but if we're going to do it the sooner we know the better um and then i'll just put out my third uh housekeeping uh uh item we did get a couple of weeks ago a work plan uh a proposed work plan uh that we have um we've been

[01:51:19] had way too much on our plate today and yesterday to consider but i hope that we can look at that again together collectively in april when we're in uh in our retreat or work session mode and finalize that. Thank you. Yes, thank you. And I did not look at it and send comments in, but I think Jim asked us for that and I would encourage all of us to look at that and send our feedback in. Yes, please do. Yes, please do. And we will certainly get those dates. I know everybody is tight on time between now and those meetings. So thank you. So we don't have the dates

[01:51:55] now. I don't know that they're solidified today. We'll make sure that that happens this week. Thank you. Sorry, Dr. Coons. So a year ago, I had the opportunity to be introduced to Virginia and to this board. The first thing I had the opportunity to do was meet with this board and the governor. And I have been here for a year, not in this position, but introduced into this position for over a year. I've had the opportunity to visit over 50 schools, talk and listen to

[01:52:29] hundreds of educators, parents, stakeholders, board members. I'm just in awe. Everybody cares about children in the Commonwealth. Everybody's focused on children. Everybody wants to do better for our kids. And it's an incredible place to be. And it's an honor to be a part of the work. It's humbling to see all of the amazing hard efforts that everyone is working for. Michelle, you said earlier, we have to do hard things better. And I know Virginia is ready and doing that. We talked about chronic absenteeism almost a year ago. We talked about how important it was that students

[01:53:08] re-engage. And our school divisions are working very hard. When I walk into schools, you see posters, you see communications, you see things on social media, and you see people working across the Commonwealth to re-engage students in learning. And that's really what attendance is.

[01:53:23] it's making sure our students are engaged in the learning opportunities. We talked about learning loss in the fall. We talked about needing high-intensity tutoring. We talked about needing a focus on that, and all of our school divisions are working hard on that. All of them are putting in tutoring opportunities, support structures, additional learning time. I had the opportunity to visit Hopewell last week, and they have created a year-long calendar with intercessions in which teachers are choosing during their time off to come in and provide opportunities, not only for catch-up learning, but for enrichment, for things that those students

[01:53:59] might not have the opportunity to do in their community. It's just inspiring to be part of this work. And the board inspired me today. You asked us to do challenging hard work for children. You asked us as educators to make sure that we rose to the challenge and we made Virginia the best place to educate children. And I will just shout out my staff because you have met most of my staff now as I've been here. And they are leaning into schools. They are working shoulder to shoulder.

[01:54:32] They are excited. And I'm so proud of our staff and I'm so proud of our board. But most importantly, I am proud of the educators across the Commonwealth that are working so hard for our children. So I just wanted to focus on the great work that I've experienced over the past year. Okay. Well, anyway, I think they're all tired. Okay. If, if, does anyone else have anything before we adjourn today? Dr. Northern. I just want to give a shout out to Fox elementary school and Richmond public

[01:55:11] schools, which hosted me for the read across America event a couple of weeks ago. I had the best time reading to kindergarten classes at Fox elementary school, and they just rolled out the red carpet for me. And I just want to thank them. And just, I got the biggest hoot out of these kindergarten kids. So thank you, Fox Elementary. Okay. And I will entertain a motion to adjourn. And we are adjourned.